

brand that produces managers for Fortune 500 companies have been the pillars of the nation's quest for knowledge

OPEN SCHOOLING:
Students in Santiniketan



SANTINIKETAN, WEST BENGAL

THE RIGHT FOUNDATION

A Nobel laureate (Amartya Sen), an Oscar winner (Satyajit Ray) and a prime minister (Indira Gandhi). How many universities in India can claim to have produced such an array of notables? But then how many universities have been established by a Noble prize winner—Rabindranath Tagore.

Santiniketan was born of Tagore's belief that school should be lively—he himself had dropped out of sheer boredom. It is a tribute to his farsightedness that Ray considered his three years here to have been the most fruitful of his life, a blend of East and West, and Sen still recalls fondly the ease with which discussions—invariably all classes were held outdoors—

moved from Indian traditional literature to classical Western thought.

In 1863, Tagore's father Maharshi Debendranath Tagore built a meditation centre at Santiniketan which later developed into a Brahmavidyalaya. Tagore carried that forward and, in 1901, Brahmacharyasrama was born with only five students. Financed by Tagore's Nobel money and his lecture fees (\$700 a scold), this cultural laboratory epitomised what the great artist Nandalal Bose taught Ray. A tree, he said, should be drawn from the base upwards, not top downwards. If the foundations are right, so will the edifice be.

by Elora Sen